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GENERAL STATSENKO AND THE REST OF THE SOVIET OFFICERS and men spent the whole night of October 26 getting ready for the attack that they expected to begin at any minute. It did not come. “The day dawned, but it was quiet, and the radar found no targets in the sky. But everyone’s nerves were strained to the breaking point, and people were weary after a sleepless night,” recalled Major Nikolai Serovoi, an officer on duty at the headquarters of the 27th Antiaircraft Division in Camagüey in central Cuba.

Around 8:00 a.m. on October 27, with tropical rain picking up and the worsening weather making an attack less likely, Pliev beat a retreat, issuing a new order to his troops. “We were ordered to go on duty in smaller units and fire only in case of direct enemy attack,” recalled Major Serovoi. Exhausted by the sleepless and nerve-racking night, the commander of Serovoi’s division, Colonel Georgii Voronkov, and many of the officers left the command post to have a bite to eat and get some sleep. Serovoi, for whom it was the start of a second consecutive twenty-four-hour shift, remained at his post. He was exhausted. “We got no sleep the whole night,” he recalled.[11]

It was around 9:00 a.m. that radar in Camagüey located a target—an airplane flying toward the eastern tip of the island at an altitude of more than 20 kilometers, or over 65,000 feet. The plane was being piloted by Major Rudolf Anderson of the United States Air Force 4080th Strategic Reconnaissance Wing. He had taken off in his Lockheed U-2F from McCoy Air Force Base in Orlando, Florida, and was picked up by Soviet radar at 9:12 a.m. Havana time entering Cuban air space over Cayo Coco Island in central Cuba. At 9:20 Anderson was already flying over the headquarters of Colonel Voronkov‘s air defense division in Camagüey. He then flew south to the town of Manzanillo, turning east toward Santiago de Cuba and passing over Guantánamo Naval Base before making a sharp eastward turn and heading over the northern shore toward Banes, a town in Holguín province.[12]

Major Anderson spent more than an hour in Cuban airspace, maintaining radio silence and not responding to Soviet radio signals that asked him to identify himself. His cameras were clicking the whole time,